

OVULATION AND THE FERTILE WINDOW

What Is Ovulation?

Ovulation is the process by which a mature egg is released from the ovary. This event marks the most fertile point in the menstrual cycle and is essential for conception.

Understanding the Fertile Window

The fertile window refers to the days in a cycle when pregnancy is possible. It spans approximately six days: the five days before ovulation and the day of ovulation itself.

- Sperm can survive in the reproductive tract for up to 5 days.
- An egg survives for only 12–24 hours after ovulation.
- Having intercourse in the days before ovulation gives sperm time to be present when the egg is released.

How to Identify Ovulation

- Cycle tracking: In a 28-day cycle, ovulation typically occurs around day 14.
- Cervical mucus changes: Mucus becomes clear, slippery, and stretchy (like raw egg whites) near ovulation.
- Basal body temperature (BBT): A slight rise in resting temperature signals that ovulation has occurred.
- Ovulation predictor kits (OPKs): Detect the LH surge that triggers ovulation.
- Period tracking apps: Can estimate fertile days based on cycle data.

Tips for Maximizing Chances

- Have intercourse every 1-2 days during the fertile window.
- Avoid excessive stress, which can delay or disrupt ovulation.

- Maintain a healthy body weight, as both underweight and overweight can affect ovulation.
- Consider tracking at least 2–3 cycles before relying on estimates.

Key Takeaway

Identifying the fertile window and timing intercourse accordingly is one of the most effective evidence-based strategies when trying to conceive.

Bloom provides educational guidance only. Always consult with a qualified healthcare professional for personalized medical advice.

Educational content informed by American College of Obstetricians and Gynecologists. (n.d.). Trying to get pregnant? Here's when to have sex. Mayo Clinic. (2023). How to get pregnant. National Health Service. (2022). Trying to get pregnant..